Many cancer facilities have been set up by the Tata Group. The latest venture includes seven state-of-the-art cancer centres in Assam that were inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in 2022, where the foundation for seven more cancer centres was also laid. Speaking on the occasion, Ratan said: ‘Assam can now say that even a small state of India has been equipped with world-class cancer treatment facilities.’

He has also employed technology to combat the menace of malaria and tuberculosis. Towards this goal, ‘Tata Trusts, in association with The Global Fund’ launched the India Health Fund in 2016. ‘The initiative was acknowledged as a landmark step in the control of dreaded diseases such as TB and Malaria.’ At the launch, Richard R. Verma, former US Ambassador to India, said that the US would join the effort ‘through USAID’. On the occasion that was attended by the ‘corporate leaders and philanthropists across the globe’, Ratan said that ‘infectious diseases such as malaria and tuberculosis though widespread are treatable and controllable’ and that ‘the India Health Fund will endeavour to combine innovation and effort for the implementation of the project at a large scale’.

Another major initiative that Ratan took was ‘to support applications of cutting-edge science and technology in genetics and genomics to solve societal problems of the country’ through the establishment of the Tata Institute for Genetics and Society (TIGS) in 2017, ‘to develop solutions to challenges in human health and agriculture’. It is a ‘binational institution that coordinates research between [University of California, San Diego] (UCSD) and research operations in India to assist in societal and infrastructure development in the area of combating vector-borne diseases’. Tata Trusts made a grant of $70 million to kickstart the project.

Ratan said that his objectives of establishing the institute were that ‘recent advancements in genetics and genomics have the potential to solve some of the most complex challenges in agriculture and healthcare and create significant societal value’. The objective was to ‘focus on research in the areas of crop improvement, food security, point of care diagnostics, and modern therapeutics’.

One of the important activities that the organization has undertaken is the reprogramming of the ‘DNA of mosquitoes to stop them [from] carrying the toxins of malaria’, says Ratan. If it is successful, the benefits it can bring, especially to the poor, would be enormous. The project also addresses all possible issues that this innovation could throw up. Environmentalist